

performed in 1742 in Dublin, where Handel had been invited to organize a concert season by the British Lord Lieutenant of Ireland. Despite objections from some critics and audiences about using such a sacred subject as Jesus in a concert performance, Messiah was soon well on its way to becoming a British institution, as was Handel himself.

“ Go to him to learn how to achieve great effects, by such simple means. ”

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN, ON HANDEL

Although disliked by some members of the royal family, Handel served, in effect, as the Hanoverian monarchy's official composer, called upon to write music to celebrate a peace or a victory. His status as a national icon was reflected in a statue of Handel by French sculptor Louis-François Roubiliac erected in the Vauxhall Pleasure Gardens in 1738.

In the early 1750s, Handel lost his sight. His last oratorio, Jephtha, was performed at Covent Garden in 1752, the composer conducting despite being almost blind. He became more pious and socially concerned in his later years, mounting performances of Messiah at the Foundling Hospital in Bloomsbury to raise money for its work with abandoned children. Throughout his life, Handel had desired wealth and fame: he died in 1759 having achieved both. His funeral in Westminster Abbey was attended by thousands. He had been adopted by the British as one of their